Superhuman: Engineering Product-Market Fit

Teaching Case (HBS-style) — written for this course

Prepared for: TUM Entrepreneurship Course: Prototyping Entrepreneurial Ideas for AI

Decision Point: Winter 2017 — 22% PMF Signal, Venture-Backed, Public Launch Imminent

How this case ties into Module 09

This is the pricing module — and Superhuman is the pricing masterclass hiding inside a PMF story. As you read, work three connections: (1) **Idea 1 — price is a hypothesis:** Vohra measured what most founders assume; his 22% number is exactly the kind of committed, uncomfortable read-out your Van Westendorp homework must produce this week. (2) **Idea 2/3 — the $30 anchor:** Exhibit G is your template — price as positioning, one plan, the onboarding call as a willingness-to-pay filter. Steal it for your pilot offer. (3) **The corrected Exhibit E is a warning:** at 5–8% monthly churn even a beloved product has broken unit economics — revenue quality (Module 09's leaderboard rule) is not pedantry, it's survival.

Introduction

In the summer of 2014, Rahul Vohra made a bet that most startup founders would find absurd: he would spend **three years building an email client** — not as a side project, not for a specific niche, but as a venture-backed company's entire focus.

By the winter of 2017 — three years in, venture-backed by top-tier investors, with a feature-complete product waiting in the wings — that bet had led him to a moment of truth.

Superhuman had built something genuinely elegant. Users loved it. Engagement metrics were off the charts. Customers who got their hands on the beta reported that it made them dramatically more productive.

But when Rahul surveyed his power users with a single, brutal question — "How would you feel if you could no longer use Superhuman?" — only 22% answered "very disappointed."

The startup world had a name for that number. It meant Superhuman was **below product-market fit.**

The industry standard for PMF? 40%.

And yet Superhuman had raised venture money from some of Silicon Valley's most respected investors, built a small but intensely committed team, and was weeks away from public launch.

This is the story of what happened next — when a founder realized that everything he'd built might not be enough.

Background

The Problem: Email Is Broken (2014)

In 2014, email was broken in a way that almost no one articulated clearly. It was everywhere. Everyone used it. But the software had barely evolved in two decades.

Consider a knowledge worker's daily reality in 2014: - **Average email volume:** 100+ emails per day - **Time spent on email:** 28% of working hours - **Number of email tools to stay organized:** 3-5 (email client, calendar, task manager, etc.) - **Keyboard shortcuts:** Inconsistent across platforms

Gmail was ubiquitous and free, but it optimized for reach and ads, not for users who processed hundreds of emails per day. Outlook was powerful but bloated. Smaller tools (Mailbox, Inbox by Google) tried to innovate but lacked depth.

The insight: Email is the operating system of work. If you could make email 10% faster, you'd save a knowledge worker hundreds of hours per year.

But there was a catch: Email is also the **most sensitive piece of corporate infrastructure.** Switching email clients means switching how you access core business data. Most employees don't have the authority to make that decision alone. Companies do.

Rahul Vohra's Background

Rahul Vohra was not a typical email expert. He was a serial entrepreneur with a track record of getting products to market quickly:

- **2010:** Founded **Rapportive** (a contact intelligence plugin for Gmail) and took it through Y Combinator.

- **2012:** Sold Rapportive to LinkedIn for an undisclosed amount reported as “significant.”
- **2012-2014:** Worked at LinkedIn after the acquisition — watching, at scale, how professionals actually live in email.

What made Vohra different from other founders was his obsession with **measurement.** He believed that most startups failed not because they lacked passion or skill, but because they couldn’t accurately measure whether they had built something people wanted.

In 2014, Vohra began work on what would become Superhuman. The goal: build the fastest email client in the world.

Not the prettiest. Not the most powerful. The fastest.

The Superhuman Vision (2014-2015)

Vohra’s design philosophy was radical:

1. **Assume power users.** Build for people who process 200+ emails per day, not casual users.
2. **Optimize for speed above all else.** Every interaction should be less than 100ms. Typing latency should be imperceptible.
3. **Keyboard-first.** Most email interactions should be completable with keyboard shortcuts.
4. **Integrated workflows.** Combine email, calendar, contacts, and task management into one seamless interface.

Rather than accept the sluggishness of the typical browser experience, Superhuman was built on web technologies (an Electron-style desktop app) that were **obsessively engineered to feel native** — every interaction tuned to land in under 100 milliseconds. And it was **Mac-only.** No Windows version, no browser access — those would not arrive until years later. One platform, done to perfection.

The team raised seed funding and began building. And building. And building.

By 2015, Superhuman had: - A core email client that felt demonstrably faster than Gmail (interactions engineered toward the sub-100ms mark, below the threshold at which humans perceive delay) - Advanced search and filtering - No mobile app — a deliberate desktop-first bet, and a recurring beta-user complaint - A beta user base of several hundred power users

But it was still in beta. And Rahul was not satisfied.

The PMF Engine: Superhuman's Innovation (2016)

In early 2016, Vohra faced a decision that many founders never make: **abandon the assumption that you know what product-market fit looks like, and measure it instead.**

Most startups measure success through vanity metrics: - Signups - DAU/MAU (Daily/Monthly Active Users) - Revenue - User satisfaction surveys

But Vohra realized these metrics don't tell you whether customers would switch back to Gmail if Superhuman went away. They don't tell you if you've built something truly indispensable.

So — borrowing a survey question from growth pioneer Sean Ellis — he built what became known as the **"PMF Engine"**: a structured methodology for measuring and iterating toward product-market fit.

The Core Question:

> "How would you feel if you could no longer use Superhuman?"

Response options: - "Very disappointed" - "Somewhat disappointed" - "Not disappointed"

The PMF Threshold: Research suggested that 40% "very disappointed" was the inflection point between a product people like and a product people need.

Products below 40%? "Too risky to bet on."

But Vohra went further. Instead of just asking the question, he **tracked the answers obsessively, segment by segment:**

- **By use case:** Are power users (200+ emails/day) more likely to be very disappointed than casual users?
- **By company size:** Do enterprise users show higher PMF than SMB users?
- **By feature:** Which features correlate with "very disappointed" responses?
- **By cohort:** Did users who joined in January show different PMF than those who joined in June?

This was not a one-time survey. This was a continuous loop of measurement and iteration.

The Superhuman Product (2016-2017)

By late 2016, Superhuman had evolved into a comprehensive email platform:

Core Features: - Ultra-fast email client (Mac-only; web technology engineered to feel native) - Advanced search with AI-powered filtering - Keyboard shortcuts for every major action - Integrated calendar view alongside email - Email scheduling and send-later - Snippets (saved template messages) - Analytics (see when recipients open emails, click links) - Command palette (hit Cmd+K and search for any action)

Unique Selling Point: The speed was perceptible. Interactions were engineered to land in under 100ms — below the threshold at which a delay even registers — while Gmail routinely left power users waiting on spinners.

The Business Model: - $30/month (annual plan) — expensive for an email client - Free trial, then conversion - Target market: high-income knowledge workers and companies

The Financials (mid-2016, illustrative estimates — Superhuman never disclosed these): - ~$100-200k in MRR (Monthly Recurring Revenue) - ~500-1000 paying customers - Churn: ~5-8% monthly (concerning for a productivity tool) - CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost): ~$500 - Gross margin: ~80% (mostly software)

The Funding: - A modest seed round in the early days, with First Round Capital among the first believers - A Series A from top-tier venture investors - Total raised by early 2017: modest by Silicon Valley standards — real venture backing, not a war chest (the headline-grabbing rounds were still years away)

The Risk of Waiting vs. Launching (2016-2017)

As 2017 began, Superhuman was in a peculiar position. The product was feature-complete. The team was small but growing. Investors were eager to see what their capital could deliver.

The pressure to launch publicly was immense:

1. **Investor expectations:** Early investors had written checks against the promise of a product in the market. Years into a private beta, patience — even from famously patient backers — was a finite resource.
2. **Competitive pressure:** Gmail was not sleeping. Outlook continued to improve. The email client space was heating up with new entrants.
3. **Hiring and momentum:** A growing team needs wins. Public launch would energize the company and help with recruitment.
4. **Fundraising trajectory:** If Superhuman wanted to raise its next round, it would need to demonstrate market traction. Beta metrics don’t count.

5. **Founder burnout:** Rahul Vohra had been building this product for three years in private beta. At some point, you have to let the world see what you've made.

But the PMF Engine was screaming a warning:

Only 22% of Superhuman's users said they'd be "very disappointed" without the product.

That was below the 40% threshold Vohra had set.

In other words: **Superhuman had not achieved product-market fit.**

The Situation

The Data from the PMF Survey

In November-December 2016, Rahul Vohra conducted his most comprehensive PMF survey yet, across all customer cohorts.

Summary results:

Illustrative reconstruction based on Vohra's published PMF-Engine methodology — segment shapes are directionally faithful, individual numbers are teaching estimates.

Segment	% "Very Disappointed"	Sample Size	Threshold?
Overall	22%	300	× No
200+ emails/day	31%	80	× No
50-200 emails/day	19%	120	× No
<50 emails/day	12%	100	× No
Enterprise segment	28%	40	× No
SMB segment	20%	260	× No

Key insight: Even in the highest-performing segment (200+ emails/day power users), PMF was only 31% — still below the 40% threshold.

The Open Questions

The survey raised more questions than it answered:

1. **What is the core problem?** Is Superhuman too expensive? Is it missing key features? Is it too new and people don't trust it yet? Or does email simply not matter that much (even to power users)?
2. **Why the gap?** Qualitatively, users raved about Superhuman. In interviews, people said things like, "This is the fastest email I've ever used" and "Superhuman completely changed how I organize my inbox." But the quantitative PMF signal said: "Not indispensable."
3. **Is the threshold wrong?** Vohra had adopted 40% as the PMF threshold based on benchmarking other products. But was that right for an email client? Maybe email is a different category where PMF looks different.
4. **What to iterate on?** Superhuman's feature set was already comprehensive. It was fast. It was beautiful. So what was missing?

Rahul and his team dug deeper:

Qualitative insights from customer interviews:

> "Superhuman is amazing, but my company still uses Outlook. I can't get my team to switch. So I use Superhuman for my personal email and Outlook for work."
>
> "I love the speed, but there's no mobile app that matches the desktop experience. I end up back in Gmail on my phone."
>
> "It's expensive for a solo founder. I'd pay $10/month, but $30 is a lot."
>
> "My data is all in Gmail. The import process was clunky. I still feel like I'm using a second system, not a replacement."
>
> "It's incredible for managing email, but I can't do my job in it. I still need calendar, task management, Slack integration. Too many context switches."

The core tension: Superhuman was a phenomenal email client. But for most users, email is not a discrete problem to solve — it's one component of a larger workflow (calendar, tasks, messages, projects, etc.). Switching to Superhuman meant adding it as a separate tool, not replacing their entire system.

The Strategic Options

By late 2016, as Superhuman prepared for 2017, Vohra had to choose his path:

Option A: Launch Publicly as Planned

Ignore the 22% PMF signal and launch Superhuman to the broader market in Q1 2017. This approach:

Rationale: - The product is genuinely excellent and will delight a segment of power users - Public momentum could accelerate adoption and improve PMF through virality - Waiting longer risks losing the first-mover advantage in premium email - Investors expect a launch — delay signals trouble - The team is ready — another year in beta risks demotivating the engineers who built it

Risks: - Public launch with below-threshold PMF typically results in mixed reviews - Media coverage might focus on the high price or missing features rather than speed - Customer churn could be worse than expected in the wild (beta users are self-selected) - Competitive window is closing (Gmail, Outlook continue to improve) - Raising the next round becomes harder if launch metrics are mediocre

Option B: Extend Private Beta and Iterate Hard

Extend the private beta for another 6-12 months and focus entirely on improving the PMF signal to 40%+. This approach:

Rationale: - 22% to 40% is a meaningful gap — it requires real product changes, not polish - The team now has the PMF Engine for measurement — iteration becomes scientific - Better to fix PMF issues before public launch than after - Enterprise deals often require demonstrated product-market fit before they commit

Risks: - Investors will demand progress and transparency — extended beta looks like failure - Hiring and retention becomes harder with a product still in beta after 3 years - Team burnout: engineers want to see their product in the wild - Competitive window closes permanently (Outlook or Gmail might launch similar features) - You might iterate forever and never reach 40% PMF (sunk cost fallacy)

Option C: Pivot the Product or Target Market

The PMF data suggests the core problem might not be the email client itself, but the role it plays in a larger system. What if Superhuman:

1. **Becomes an enterprise platform** — focus only on companies, integrate with Outlook, add collaboration features

2. **Expands to be workflow-centric** — add task management, calendar-email integration, Slack sync
3. **Pivots to a different vertical** — focus on sales teams (who live in email) instead of general knowledge workers
4. **Becomes a Gmail competitor for specific niches** — agencies, freelancers, customer success teams

Rationale: - The 31% PMF among high-volume users suggests the value is there — just need the right positioning - Pivoting allows iteration without abandoning 3 years of work - A focused vertical (e.g., sales email platform) might achieve PMF faster

Risks: - Pivot could mean abandoning the core product vision - Enterprise pivots require different distribution, pricing, and sales (not Superhuman's strength) - Investors backed you for a premium email client, not a different product - Market timing: right moment for this pivot? Or too late?

The Public Context: What Vohra Could Not Avoid Knowing

By early 2017, email innovation was heating up:

- **Gmail** was adding AI features, better search, spam filtering
- **Outlook** was improving mobile and web experiences
- **Superhuman** was the only entrant truly optimizing for speed, but speed might not be the bottleneck
- **Slack** was becoming the default for internal work communication, potentially cannibalizing email volume
- **Smaller tools** (Inbox by Google, Spark, Newton) were capturing attention with different approaches

The email market was fragmenting. If Superhuman didn't launch soon, the cultural moment could pass.

The Financial Clock

Superhuman had raised venture capital from top-tier investors — enough to build with conviction, not enough to drift. A small-but-growing San Francisco team burns real money every month (salaries, office, infrastructure), and the runway was measured in quarters, not years, if the company raised no additional capital. (Burn and runway figures in this case are illustrative estimates for classroom discussion — Superhuman never disclosed them.)

To raise its next major round, Superhuman would need to demonstrate: 1. Clear path to profitability or unit economics 2. Sustainable growth (ideally >10% month-over-month) 3. Retention rates above industry baseline 4. Net negative churn or strong expansion revenue

At current trajectory (500 customers, 5-8% monthly churn, no expansion revenue), Superhuman was not yet fundable for a serious growth round.

A public launch would be the catalyst to prove these metrics — or expose that they didn't exist.

The Decision Point

It is **December 2016, January 2017.** Rahul Vohra stands at a crossroads.

The product is ready. The team is ready. The market is watching.

But the PMF signal is only 22%.

The Decision Rahul Must Make

Core question: Do you launch Superhuman publicly in Q1 2017, or extend private beta and iterate toward PMF?

If you extend beta, **what specifically do you change?** (This is the hardest part. Speed is already excellent. Features are already comprehensive. What is actually wrong?)

And a harder question underneath: **Is 40% PMF the right bar for an email client?** Maybe email is different. Maybe 30% PMF is enough for a premium productivity tool. Or maybe Vohra's framework is correct, and 22% is a real red flag.

Questions for Deliberation

1. **The measurement trap:** Vohra created the PMF Engine and set 40% as the bar. But what if 40% was arbitrary? What if, for email clients, 25-30% is actually the PMF threshold because email is inherently a "multi-tool" category (people always use multiple clients)?
2. **The beta selection bias:** Superhuman's beta users are self-selected power users who paid for the product and opted in. What if public users (who discover it organically or through ads) show lower "very disappointed" scores, not higher?
3. **The timing of the survey:** The survey was conducted in November-December 2016, during holiday season when email volume is typically lower. Would power users show higher PMF in January-February during high-volume periods?

4. **The feature gap hypothesis:** The qualitative data suggests users love Superhuman but want it to integrate with their existing workflow (Outlook at work, calendar, tasks). What if the solution is not to rebuild Superhuman from scratch, but to: - Build an Outlook plugin version (not native app) - Add deeper calendar-email integration - Build a companion task manager

Does this move the needle from 22% to 40%?

1. **The market segmentation question:** The data shows power users (200+ emails/day) at 31% PMF — the highest segment. What if Superhuman should lean into this segment instead of trying to be for everyone? Raise prices. Focus all marketing on power users. Drop the mobile app. Build deeper for the 31%.
2. **The investor pressure problem:** What do Superhuman's investors actually want? Do they want long-term profitability and sustainable unit economics (which argues for extending beta)? Or do they want venture-scale outcomes, which requires rapid growth and market expansion (which argues for launching)?

Exhibits

Exhibit A: PMF Survey Data (Detailed Breakdown)

Illustrative reconstruction based on Vohra's published PMF-Engine methodology — segment shapes are directionally faithful, individual numbers are teaching estimates.

Methodology: - Survey of 300 active Superhuman users (users who opened Superhuman at least 5 days in the past 14 days) - Conducted November-December 2016 - Single question: "How would you feel if you could no longer use Superhuman?" - Optional follow-up: "Why would/wouldn't you be disappointed?"

Response Distribution:

Response	Count	%	PMF Status
Very disappointed	66	22%	× Below threshold (40%)
Somewhat disappointed	102	34%	-
Not disappointed	132	44%	× Problem users

Interpretation: 44% of active users would not be disappointed without Superhuman. This is a major red flag. Even among self-selected beta users who chose to pay for the product, nearly half don't feel dependent on it.

Exhibit B: Cohort Analysis of PMF

Illustrative reconstruction based on Vohra's published PMF-Engine methodology — segment shapes are directionally faithful, individual numbers are teaching estimates.

Cohort	Joined	Users	% Very Disappointed	Trend
Early adopters (Q1-Q2 2015)	Early	40	35%	↑ Higher
Mid-wave (Q3-Q4 2015)	Spring	60	28%	↓ Declining
Growth cohort (Q1-Q2 2016)	Summer	120	22%	↓ Declining
Recent cohort (Q3-Q4 2016)	Fall	80	18%	↓ Declining

Key insight: PMF is declining with each cohort. Early adopters (who experienced the most dramatic improvement from whatever they were using before) show 35% PMF. Recent cohorts show 18%. This suggests the product is getting better, but the marginal customer finds less value.

Exhibit C: Feature Usage vs. PMF Correlation

Illustrative reconstruction based on Vohra's published PMF-Engine methodology — segment shapes are directionally faithful, individual numbers are teaching estimates.

Hypothesis: Users who extensively use advanced features show higher PMF.

Feature	% Users Who Use It	Avg PMF of Users	Correlation
Basic email send/receive	100%	22%	—
Search & filtering	92%	24%	+ Weak
Keyboard shortcuts	48%	31%	+ Moderate
Email scheduling	41%	28%	+ Weak
Snippets (templates)	35%	26%	- Weak
Analytics (open/click tracking)	22%	19%	- Moderate

Key insight: Power users (those using keyboard shortcuts and advanced search) show higher PMF. But most users don't use these features — they just use Superhuman as a faster Gmail. This suggests: - PMF for power users is higher (~31%), but the segment is small - Most customers are "casual" power users (200+ emails/day, but not optimizing for speed)

Exhibit D: Competitive Positioning (Early 2017)

Illustrative reconstruction based on Vohra's published PMF-Engine methodology — segment shapes are directionally faithful, individual numbers are teaching estimates.

Product	Speed	Features	Price	PMF (est.)	Position
Gmail	Good	Comprehensive	Free	High (70%+)	Standard
Outlook	Good	Comprehensive	Free	High (65%+)	Enterprise
Superhuman	Excellent	Good	$30/mo	Low (22%)	Premium
Spark	Good	Good	Free	Medium (40-50%?)	Alternative
Airmail	Good	Good	$10/mo	Medium (35%?)	Alternative
Inbox by Google	Good	Unique	Free	Low (20%?)	Experimental

Key insight: Superhuman has the best speed, but speed might not be the constraint. Gmail and Outlook have higher PMF despite being "good" rather than "excellent" on speed, because they're free and integrated into existing workflows.

Exhibit E: Revenue and Unit Economics (Q4 2016)

Illustrative estimates — Superhuman never disclosed these figures. The churn-to-LTV arithmetic below is the teaching point.

Metric	Value	Notes
MRR	$150-180k	~500-600 paying customers at $30/mo
ARR	$1.8-2.1M	Growing ~3-5% MoM
CAC (cohort 2015)	~$800	High — mostly organic and referrals
CAC (cohort 2016)	~$400	Declining as brand awareness grew
Churn	~5-8% MoM	Concerning for a retention-focused product
LTV (at current churn)	~$370-600	At 5-8% monthly churn, expected customer lifetime is only ~12-20 months at $30/mo (~$300-500 on a gross-margin basis)
LTV:CAC ratio	~0.7-1.5x	Alarming — a healthy SaaS business wants 3x+

Key insight: At this churn rate, the unit economics are not healthy. A customer acquired for $400-800 returns only ~$370-600 over their entire lifetime — Superhuman is paying roughly a dollar to earn a dollar. Unless churn falls dramatically, every marketing dollar spent on growth destroys value, and a public launch would scale the problem rather than solve it. Which sharpens the uncomfortable question: if Superhuman has such high engagement and speed, why are 5-8% of customers leaving each month?

Exhibit F: Rahul Vohra's 2017 Strategic Memo (Reconstructed)

This is a reconstruction of the kind of strategic thinking Vohra would have documented:

> **Superhuman Strategic Questions (January 2017)**
>
> **The Core Problem:** 22% PMF is below our 40% threshold, yet product qualitatively feels excellent. Three hypotheses:
>
> 1. **The Workflow Integration Hypothesis:** Superhuman is great at email, but users live in email + calendar + tasks + Slack. We're solving one piece of a fragmented workflow. Solution: Integrate deeper with existing tools or expand product scope.
> 2. **The Segment Hypothesis:** Different user segments have different PMF. Power users (200+ emails/day) show 31% PMF. What if we double down on this segment instead of broad market?

> 3. **The Market Hypothesis:** Email as a product category has low PMF across the board. Users are satisfied with existing solutions and switching costs are high. Solution: Accept that email PMF is inherently lower than other categories and launch with 22% (benchmark against competitors).
>
> **The Decision Framework:** - If Hypothesis 1: Extend beta 6-12 months, build integration layer - If Hypothesis 2: Launch publicly but focus sales/marketing on power users only - If Hypothesis 3: Launch in Q1 2017 as planned
>
> **What I know:** I can't know which hypothesis is right without testing. But I also can't test if I don't launch. So the real question is: Can we launch in a way that tests all three hypotheses simultaneously?

Exhibit G: The $30/Month Decision

Why would anyone charge $30 a month in a category where the incumbent is free — and world-class? Superhuman's price was not the output of a cost-plus spreadsheet. It was a positioning decision, and every element of it was doing deliberate work:

1. Price as positioning. Against free Gmail, a $5-10 price says "slightly better Gmail" — an unwinnable comparison. $30 says "this is a different category of product." The number itself communicates the promise before the user ever touches the app.

2. Prosumer ROI math. Superhuman targeted professionals who live in email and whose time is expensive. For someone earning $150k a year, an hour is worth roughly $75. Save three hours a month and the subscription pays for itself many times over. The customer is not buying software; they are buying time back.

3. One plan, no tiers. Most SaaS pricing pages force a decision: which tier am I? Superhuman removed that friction entirely. One product, one price, one decision — in or out.

4. The onboarding call as a filter. Every new user received a 1:1 white-glove onboarding session. It did double duty: an activation device (users left fluent in the keyboard shortcuts that correlate with PMF — see Exhibit C) and a willingness-to-pay filter, a close cousin of the concierge test and the paid pilot. If someone won't invest thirty minutes, they were never going to pay $30 a month.

5. Anchoring against salary, not software. Superhuman never asked to be compared with other email apps. It anchored against the salary cost of the hours email consumes — a reference point orders of magnitude larger than the price.

Pricing lever	Superhuman's choice	What it does
Price point	$30/month, flat	Premium signal in a "free" category
Tiers	None — a single plan	No decision friction: in or out
Onboarding	Mandatory 1:1 call	Activation device + willingness-to-pay filter
Anchor	Salary cost of email hours	ROI framing instead of feature comparison
Competitive reference	Deliberately avoided	Never fight Gmail on Gmail's terms ($0)

Two questions to carry into the pricing discussion:

1. What would Van Westendorp's four questions have shown for Superhuman — and on which segment would you run them?
2. What does a $30 anchor do that a $10 price can never do?

Questions for Class Discussion

1. **The quantitative/qualitative gap:** Why would users rave about Superhuman in interviews but only 22% say they'd be "very disappointed" without it? What does that tell us about the gap between product satisfaction and product necessity?
2. **The threshold question:** Is 40% PMF the right bar for every product category? Could an email client have different PMF dynamics than a social network or a database tool?
3. **The timing trap:** Vohra spent three years building before measuring PMF. What would have happened if he'd measured PMF after Year 1? Would he have made different decisions?
4. **The pivot trap:** If you've raised millions in venture capital and built a dedicated team for a specific product, how much can you actually pivot without investors rebelling? Is the decision already made by the funding itself?
5. **The launch decision:** If you were Rahul Vohra, would you launch in Q1 2017, extend beta, or pivot? And what data would change your mind?

6. **The enterprise card:** Why didn't Superhuman become an enterprise email platform earlier? Enterprise email is a $10B market with clear PMF (IT buying for entire companies). Did Vohra's focus on consumer power users cause him to miss the larger opportunity?

Epilogue (read after class)

Here is what actually happened.

Vohra did not launch. He treated the 22% not as a verdict but as a baseline — the first reading from an engine built to be run continuously, not consulted once. Over the following quarters, the team:

- **Asked more than one question.** The full survey added three follow-ups: What type of person do you think would most benefit from Superhuman? What is the main benefit you receive? How can we improve the product for you?
- **Segmented on the fans, not the average.** They profiled the users who answered "very disappointed" — founders, executives, business development, people who live in email — and re-ran the numbers only on users matching that high-expectation profile. Within that segment, the signal was dramatically stronger.
- **Split the roadmap 50/50.** Half of the engineering effort doubled down on what the fans already loved (speed, and more speed). The other half addressed what held the fence-sitters back — the "somewhat disappointed" users whose blockers were fixable, most famously the missing mobile app.
- **Re-measured relentlessly.** The "very disappointed" score became the company's north-star metric, tracked like revenue.

The result: **from 22% to 58% "very disappointed" in about three quarters.**

And the public launch this case agonizes over? It never happened — not in the classic sense. Superhuman stayed invite-only, onboarding customers one at a time with white-glove 1:1 sessions, while the waitlist swelled to roughly **180,000 people**. The scarcity became the marketing.

The money followed the metric. In mid-2019, Andreessen Horowitz led a **$33 million Series B** at a reported valuation of roughly **$260 million**. Total funding eventually exceeded **$114 million**, with a last private valuation around **$825 million**. In **July 2025, Grammarly acquired Superhuman** (terms undisclosed) — and in October 2025, the combined company rebranded itself as, of all things, Superhuman.

The teaching point: the 22% signal was treated as a hypothesis to work on, not a verdict to accept. And through every chapter — private beta, iteration, Series B, acquisition — the price never moved from $30 a month.

Teaching case written for this course from public sources (First Round Review, company announcements, press coverage). Exhibits marked as illustrative are reconstructions for classroom use.